

Lesson 16

Case Study: Difficult Conversations



Warm-Up

Have you ever had a difficult conversation at work? What made it difficult?

- Was it about a mistake?
- Was it with a manager or colleague?
- How did it end?



Case-study

Study the case-study below and answer the questions

Case Study: Feedback on Performance

Background:

The marketing team at XYZ Corp has recently launched a new campaign. While the campaign received good initial traction, the overall results were below expectations. The team manager, Sarah, needs to have a difficult conversation with one of her team members, Tom, who was responsible for a significant portion of the campaign's content creation.

Situation:

Tom has been a valuable member of the team for the past two years, but Sarah has noticed that his recent work lacks the creativity and attention to detail that he previously demonstrated. In addition, Tom has been showing signs of disengagement during team meetings and often appears distracted.

Objectives of the Conversation:

- Sarah wants to provide constructive feedback to Tom about his recent performance without demotivating him.

- She needs to understand Tom's perspective and any underlying issues that might be affecting his work.
- Sarah hopes to encourage Tom to regain his enthusiasm for the project and to discuss possible solutions to improve his performance.

Case-study Analysis:

1. How should Sarah prepare for the conversation? What points should she consider to ensure the meeting is constructive?
2. How can Sarah ensure that Tom feels comfortable during this difficult conversation?
3. What questions should Sarah ask to understand Tom's situation better? What specific feedback should Sarah provide, and how should she deliver it?
4. How can they collaboratively create an action plan for improvement?



Practice

A. Role-play Conversation

Instructions: Practice role-playing the given scenario. To practice effective delegation skills, take note of the highlighted phrases used in this dialogue.

Situation: *Jamie has missed two important deadlines. Alex needs to address this issue without making Jamie feel attacked.*

Alex: Hi Jamie, do you have a moment to talk?

Jamie: Sure, what's up?

Alex: Thanks. I'd like to share some feedback about the last couple of projects.

Jamie: Okay, I'm listening.

Alex: I'm a bit concerned about the missed deadlines. I noticed the last two tasks were submitted late, and it affected the rest of the team.

Jamie: Yes, I know. I've been under a lot of pressure lately.

Alex: I understand this might be frustrating for you. Let's try to stay focused on solutions. Could we find a way to help you manage your workload better?

Jamie: That would be helpful. Maybe I could work with someone on the next task?

Alex: That sounds reasonable. I see your point, and I appreciate your honesty. Let's check in again next week to see how things are going.

Jamie: Thanks, Alex. I'll do my best to improve.

Role-play Analysis

1. Which phrases did Alex use to express concern politely?
2. How did Alex acknowledge Jamie's feelings?
3. Do you think the conversation was successful? Why or why not?
4. What other phrases could Alex have used to stay calm or supportive?

Discussion

- Have you ever been in a situation like Alex or Jamie? How did you handle it? Would you do anything differently now?
- Why is it important to stay calm and polite during difficult conversations at work? What can happen if we don't?

B. Multiple Choice Speaking Activity

Instructions: Choose the best phrase to use in a professional conversation. Then practice saying the full sentence.

1. You need to give polite feedback to a colleague. What do you say?

- a) You're doing it wrong.
- b) I'd like to share some feedback.
- c) You always make mistakes.

2. You want to express concern. What phrase do you use?

- a) I'm really mad about this.
- b) Why did you do that?
- c) I'm a bit concerned about this situation.

3. You want to stay positive. What do you say?

- a) Let's try to stay focused on solutions.
- b) This is all your fault.
- c) I don't care anymore.

4. You want to show empathy. What can you say?

- a) That's not my problem.
- b) I understand this might be frustrating.
- c) Calm down.

5. You need to suggest a change. What do you say?

- a) Just do it my way.
- b) Could we find a better approach?
- c) Why are you so slow?



Production

YOUR TURN TO LEAD THE CONVERSATION

Instructions:

1. Choose a Scenario

- A colleague is often late for meetings.
- A coworker is speaking negatively in front of clients.
- A colleague keeps interrupting during discussions.

2. Preparation

- Each student chooses a role (e.g., manager/employee or peer/peer).
- Plan what you will say using **key phrases** from the lesson:
 - ✓ I'd like to share some feedback...
 - ✓ I'm a bit concerned about...
 - ✓ Could we find a way to...
 - ✓ I understand this might be frustrating for you.
 - ✓ Let's stay focused on solutions.
 - ✓ I see your point.

3. Role-Play

- Act out the conversation in pairs.
- Encourage natural tone, polite language, and appropriate intonation.

Example Conversation

Sarah: Hi Mark, can I talk to you for a minute?

Mark: Of course, what's up?

Sarah: I'd like to share some feedback. In meetings, you sometimes interrupt others.

Mark: Oh, I didn't realize that. I just get excited about ideas.

Sarah: I understand that. Let's try to focus on giving everyone a chance to speak.

Mark: Got it. I'll be more careful next time.

Discussion:

- What key phrases did you use during your conversation? Were they effective in keeping the conversation polite and professional? Why or why not?
- How did you handle the other person's feelings or reactions in your conversation? What would you do differently next time to improve the outcome?



Key Vocabulary

Word/Phrase	Use	Example
<i>I'd like to share some feedback.</i>	To start a polite conversation about performance or behavior.	<i>I'd like to share some feedback</i> about your last presentation.
<i>I'm a bit concerned about...</i>	To express a worry or issue gently.	<i>I'm a bit concerned about</i> the missed deadlines last week.
<i>Let's stay focused on solutions.</i>	To shift the conversation to problem-solving.	<i>I understand the issue—</i> <i>let's stay focused on solutions.</i>
<i>Could we find a way to...?</i>	To suggest a collaborative solution.	<i>Could we find a way to</i> better manage the workload?
<i>I understand this might be frustrating.</i>	To show empathy and acknowledge the other person's feelings.	<i>I understand this might be frustrating,</i> but we need to discuss it.



Wrap-Up

The single biggest problem in communication is the illusion that it has taken place. – George Bernard Shaw

What was the most useful phrase or strategy you learned today?